



THIS LINE SHALL BE CONSIDERED AS A PERPETUAL MARK AND BOUND

THE TREATY OF Tordesillas (1494)

IN CONTEXT

FOCUS

**Spanish and Portuguese
American conquests**

BEFORE

1492 Columbus makes his first journey to the New World, signaling the beginning of Spanish interest in the area.

AFTER

1500 Pedro Álvares Cabral claims Brazil for Portugal.

1521 Hernán Cortés completes his conquest of the Aztec Empire.

1525 The first Spanish settlement in Colombia, Santa Marta, is established.

1532 Francisco Pizarro begins the Spanish campaign to conquer the Inca Empire.

1598 Juan de Oñate founds the first Spanish settlement in California.

Spain and Portugal signed a treaty on June 7, 1494, at Tordesillas in Spain, that resolved the countries' disputes about the possession of newly discovered territory. The rulers settled on a meridian 370 leagues west of the Cape Verde Islands as a line of demarcation. All the lands to the west of this line would belong to Spain; all those to the east would belong to Portugal. The line was chosen because of its location: it lies roughly halfway

between the Cape Verde Islands, which already belonged to Portugal, and the Caribbean islands, which Christopher Columbus had claimed for Spain in 1492.

By the 1490s both countries were discovering substantial territories, including lands in the New World, although at this point the size and extent of the Americas was unclear to Europeans. In spite of the fact that the Spanish Crown had funded Columbus's voyages, Spain's claim to his discoveries was not clear-cut. The 1479 Alcaçovas treaty between the Catholic Monarchs of Spain and the rulers of Portugal gave all newly discovered lands south of the Canary Islands to Portugal. When Columbus landed at Lisbon after his first voyage, he told John II, king of Portugal, that he was claiming Hispaniola and Cuba for his Spanish backers. John wrote to Spain's rulers immediately to say that he was preparing to send his own ships to claim the Caribbean for Portugal.

Legalizing possession

To prevent such disputes erupting each time a navigator made a fresh discovery, the leaders of both countries decided to

“ I and my companions
suffer from a disease of the
heart that can be cured
only with gold.

Hernán Cortés, 1519 ”